

playing just another model and not the predictable show-stopper.

But more than the B-town crowd and the Page Three preen queens, it was the behind-the-scenes buzz that kept fashion watchers on their stillettos. LFW's promising young entourage finally came to the event's rescue and resuscitated the almost-comatose couture animals. Impressive glimpses of originality, earnestness and the ability to innovate earmarked the collections of Vineet Bahl, Rahul & Firdos, Arjun Saluja, Agnimitra Paul and Anand Kabra.

With the accent on wearability

personal orders between shows. Nachiket Barve's highly original and understated line was lapped up by domestic buyers looking for designs with a difference.

"I want to once and for all dispel the myth that no business takes place at LFW," says Delhi designer Anupama Dayal, having rolled in orders from domestic buyers like Aza, Melange, Evoluzione, Zoya, Ensemble and Ffolio besides international clients from New York, Indonesia, Toronto and London. "Domestic buyers are consistent and order around 200 pieces every season, while international buyers

bles, pin-tucks, pleats and smocking in shades of ecru, moss green and ochre, Bijoya innovated with block prints on saris, kaftans and breeches. Bhimte's clever collection Rag Doll drew on origami patterns on hems, sleeves and yokes.

While fashion's love affair with films continued at LFW with Katrina Kaif, *Chak De! India*'s Vidya Malvade, Konkona Sen-Sharma and Neetu Chandra taking a 10-second trendy trapeze—and we sheepishly admit we were agog to see Kareena Kapoor and Saif Ali Khan make their first formal appearance together for Malhotra—

MALE ALERT

LEACONAT HEMANT:

Bonjour Bombay saw men walk the ramp in mohawks and tight leather rugby shorts, gathered tafta trousers and an eye-catching checkered 'Fly me to the Moon' suit.



ARJUN KHANNA:

Impeccably crafted and intricately embroidered sherwanis, single and double-breasted jackets, tunics and waistcoats walked the ramp in shades of indigo blue, grey, wine and gold.



ABHISHEK DUTTA:

Transcendence saw detailing in the form of pleats, patches, embellishment and zippers on western and ethnic wear in earthy and pastel tones.

increasing, the newbies seem to be wisening up to market dynamics, throwing in highly saleable saris and Indian nuances in their line-ups. And the move seems to have worked well, with their order books abounding with domestic buyers. While Rahul & Firdos's inventive, ivory-bathed, seamless line had the buyers lining up and even Albert Morris of Brown's making more than one stop-over, Mukherjee's promising protégé Nimita Rathod was reeling in Indian consignments, with social queen bee Queenie Dhody packing in some

might buy a maximum of 70 pieces," explains Dayal. Bahl, who already retails in Paris and Milan, preferred to test local waters this season with some saris for the desi touch. "It worked for me. We are too enamoured of the West," he says, tallying orders from most Indian buyers and Indo Mix, New York.

The GenNext show, now the highlight of LFW, also threw up a few pleasant surprises in the form of Rimzim Dadu, Swati Bhimte and Bijoya Mukherjee. While Dadu's collection My Village played on texturing with bub-

this event swiftly needs to rise out of its obsession with celebrities.

Despite the prevailing confusion between couture and prêt preferences, the future of fashion is undoubtedly alive and thriving at LFW. With any luck, the young aspirants won't let their originality be smothered by some wannabe-actor's ample posterior. Like a senior designer said, "If you have Bipasha walk the ramp and make your clothes look good, go for it. But why waste an outfit on a five-foot nothing Minnisha Lamba for want of a few more flashbulbs?" Touche, we say.